

The Global Burden of Mental Illness

Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

Global Data • 2023 • Policy Audience

Hundreds of Millions Affected

1 in 3

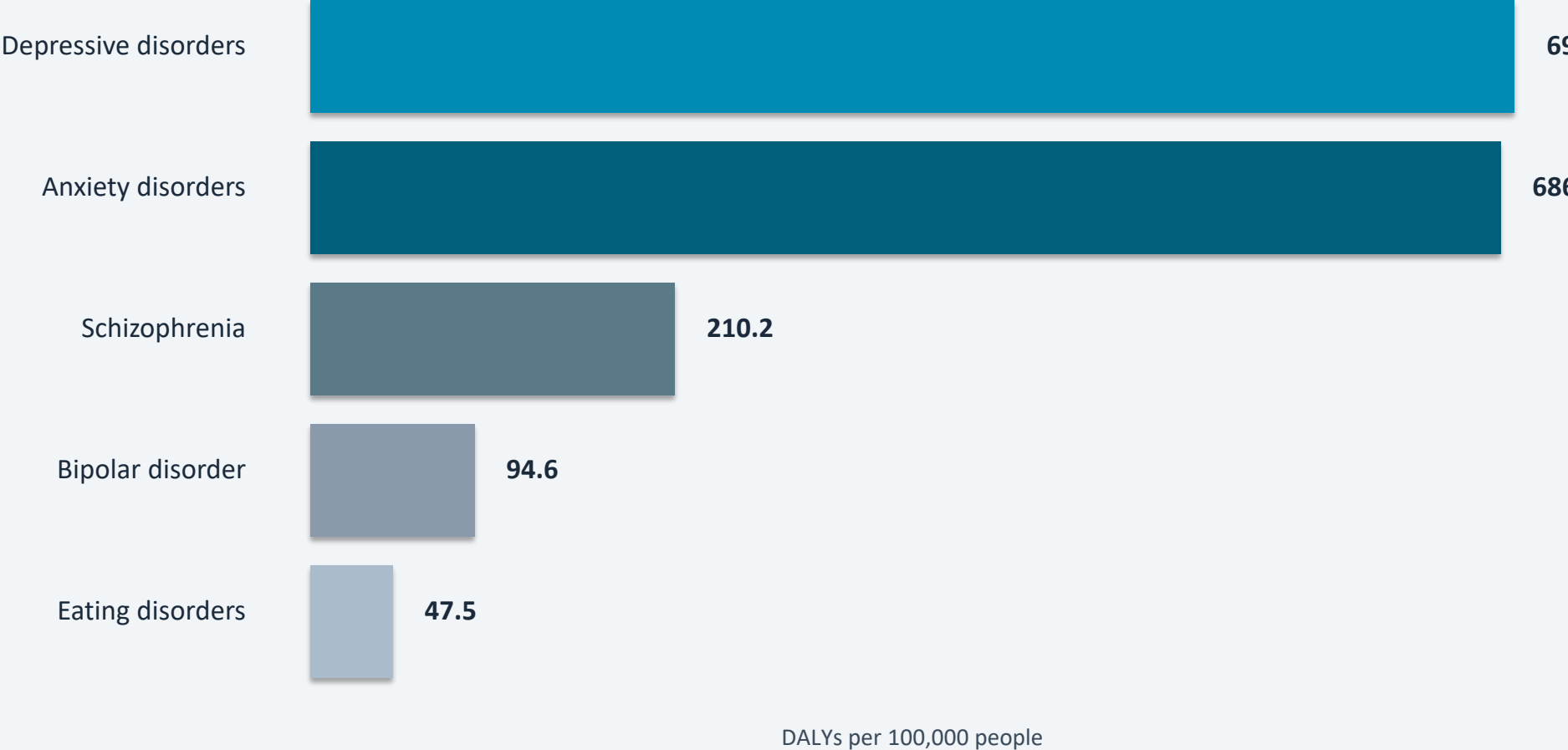
Women will experience
major depression in their lifetime

1 in 5

Men will experience
major depression in their lifetime

Mental health conditions span from common disorders like depression and anxiety — affecting hundreds of millions globally — to less prevalent but severe conditions such as schizophrenia and bipolar disorder. All carry significant disability impact, making mental health a central policy concern for health systems worldwide.

Depression and Anxiety Dominate Disease Burden



Note: DALYs combine years of life lost to premature death and years lived with disability. Together, depression and anxiety account for ~80% of total mental health DALYs across these five categories.

Source: Our World in Data / IHME Global Burden of Disease (2025)

Depression and Anxiety Carry Nearly Equal Disease Burden

Depressive
Disorders

694.6

Anxiety
Disorders

686.5

~Equal Burden • Together ~80% of Mental Health DALYs

Depression and anxiety are the two largest contributors to the global mental health disease burden, with nearly identical DALY rates of 694.6 and 686.5 per 100,000 people respectively. This near-parity underscores that both conditions demand equal policy attention and resource allocation.

Schizophrenia & Bipolar: Lower Prevalence, Severe Individual Impact

Schizophrenia

210.2

DALYs per 100,000

While affecting far fewer people than depression or anxiety, schizophrenia carries a disproportionately high individual burden — reflecting severe disability, early onset, and long disease duration.

Bipolar Disorder

94.6

DALYs per 100,000

Bipolar disorder also shows a high individual disability burden relative to its population prevalence. It typically emerges in late adolescence or early adulthood, with lasting impact across the lifespan.

Treatment Is Available but Often Lacking or Poor Quality

Mental illnesses are treatable — yet significant barriers mean millions do not receive adequate care.

STIGMA

Many feel uncomfortable disclosing symptoms to healthcare providers or even to people they know.

ACCESS

Treatment is often unavailable, especially in low- and middle-income countries.

QUALITY

Even where treatment exists, it may be of poor quality or poorly suited to the individual.

Underreporting: Discomfort with disclosure makes estimating true prevalence difficult — actual burden may be higher than reported figures suggest.

How People Cope: From Medication to Faith to Family Conversations

Global survey data reveals wide variation in how people deal with anxiety or depression.



Prescribed Medication

Common in higher-income settings where access to healthcare and pharmaceuticals is greater



Religious / Spiritual Activities

Prevalent across many regions worldwide, often serving as a primary coping mechanism



Talking to Friends or Family

Widely reported globally, reflecting the role of social networks in mental wellbeing

Policy implication: Interventions must account for this diversity — a one-size-fits-all approach is insufficient. Culturally sensitive, multi-modal strategies are needed.

Key Takeaways

Policy Priorities for Scaling Mental Health Interventions

- 1 Depression and anxiety together represent the overwhelming majority of mental health DALYs (~80%), each generating ~690 per 100,000 — policy must prioritize both.
- 2 Schizophrenia and bipolar carry a disproportionate individual burden relative to prevalence; specialized care must be maintained alongside scaled common-disorder interventions.
- 3 Treatment exists but access and quality remain inadequate across much of the world — closing the treatment gap is a systemic priority.
- 4 Stigma suppresses both help-seeking and accurate epidemiological data — investment in destigmatization supports better data and better outcomes.
- 5 Scale evidence-based interventions for common mental disorders while sustaining specialized services for severe conditions — both are essential.